of Opposition Tika Ram Jully recently flagged reports that a faction was trying to convert the RCA from a society under the cooperative department into a trust with permanent trustees. Kumawat's removal is widely seen as linked to this.

The crisis reflects the turbulent transition of political power in the state. Vaibhav Gehlot, son of former chief minister Ashok Gehlot, had been heading the RCA—in the original Congress version of cricket as a dynastic league—but stepped down in the face of the new regime's aggressive posturing, including threats of FIRs and investigations into his tenure. An FIR was indeed registered about alleged irregularities in a stadium project near Jaipur, but lack of progress in the case has sparked speculation about a possible cover-up.

Takeaways

- **Ad hoc panel, set up to hold cricket body's polls within three months, reigning for two years**
- **BJP rivals jockey for control in a 'dynastic premier league'**
- **Fears of a full capture of RCA by changing its legal status**

ALL BETS ARE OFF

The ad hoc committee, too, began life controversially, under BJP MLA Jaideep Bihani, who publicly alleged betting and match-fixing involving Rajasthan Royals and accused the RSCC of black-marketing IPL tickets. Charges of cash-for-selection flew back and forth between rival BJP camps.

Union sports minister Rajyavardhan Singh Rathore was initially keen to reshape the RCA with a new set of loyalists, while another influential camp led by state health minister Gajendra Singh Khimsar jockeyed to retain control—panel member Dhananjay Singh is his son. The standoff produced the ad hoc arrangement that now looks to get entrenched as a long-term reality. ■

▶ GUJARAT

UCC Gets Its Second Lab in Gujarat

The original home of Hindutva—Gujarat—gets to experiment with India's second draft of the Uniform Civil Code. Though nuancing Uttarakhand's version, it preserves its blind spots on constitutional freedoms

By **Jumana Shah**

YOU COULD CALL IT THE BETA PROTOTYPE of the Uniform Civil Code (UCC), one level of evolution above Uttarakhand's pilot version. It needed a real-life, yet controlled environment for its test run. And what better place than the original laboratory of Hindutva? Gujarat thus becomes the second Indian state to move towards an omnibus civil law.

The Uniform Civil Code Bill, 2026, passed by the Gujarat assembly on March 24-25, brings under a single legal framework many social phenomena: live-in relationships, inheritance, marriage, divorce and family law. A significant shift for the state, it marks a tentative juridical step for India in a complex area, with questions of constitutional incongruity left open-ended.

POLYGAMY OUT

The bill mandates registration of live-in relationships, grants legal recognition to children born from such unions, standardises inheritance rules, prohibits polygamy, and retains a uniform minimum age for marriage—21 for men, 18 for women. The provisions depart in key ways from Sharia law, particularly on polygamy, which is permitted under Islamic personal law, and inheritance, where shares are traditionally gender-differentiated. By introducing a gender-neutral framework, the bill effectively overrides religion-based personal laws for those it applies to. In another enduring irony for what purports to be a uniform code, Scheduled Tribes stay exempted from the framework.

LIVE IN? TELL US FIRST

Gujarat's bill closely follows the template of Uttarakhand's UCC, passed in 2024. But it's more expansive in structure, with detailed procedural provisions governing registration, maintenance, termination of live-in relationships, and administrative oversight. The Gujarat UCC also frames such registration as being "for record"—a formulation differing in tone from Uttarakhand's more compliance-driven approach, yet seen by critics as enabling an intrusive state meddling in private rights.

Politically, the bill generated instant opposition, even if in degrees. The All India Majlis-e-Ittehadul Muslimeen staged a public protest. "It's a tactic to divide India communally. If it's 'Uniform', why exclude the tribals?" asked its state chief Sabir Kabliwala. The Congress,